

Unit 1: Understanding Gender

This unit explores the concepts of gender identity, gender roles, and societal expectations of men and women. Group participants will engage with the following thematic questions:

- How does gender impact how I move through the world and the experiences I have?
- How does my understanding of gender roles impact the way I form relationships and behave in them?
- What is toxic masculinity, and how does it affect individuals and our culture?

Lesson 1: My Gender Identity

Introductions and Icebreakers

Choose an introduction activity and icebreaker activity from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

This lesson is called “My Gender Identity.” We’ll be defining some terms about gender and sex, then we’ll spend some time discussing different ways gender influences the way we see ourselves and how others see us.

Sex and gender identities shape our social experiences. Being male, female, intersex; a man, woman, or non-binary person influences how you see yourself and how other people see and respond to you. The first things we’ll cover in this group are sex and gender, in order to give us an understanding of how these concepts operate in society and in our own lives.

Sex is a term that references one’s biological form. Sex describes different types of bodies. Terms for sex you might be familiar with include male, female, and intersex. Gender is about feeling and self-identity in response to social, cultural, and behavioral factors. Terms that we hear often to describe gender are “men” and “women.” Gender is often misunderstood as being inherently related to sex, that is what your body looks like and how you were born. We have language for describing the relationship between your sex and your gender: if your assigned sex at birth aligns culturally with

your gender (like a female woman or a male man), then you are cisgender. If your sex and gender do not align with cultural expectations, you may identify as trans or gender non-conforming in some capacity.

Often, we discuss sex and gender as binaries: systems of balanced opposites. As we learn more in the sciences and social sciences, we can reframe gender and sex as spectrums to describe the experiences of more people and bodies. This understanding of gender is important for people who don't fall neatly into binary descriptions of sex and gender. In fact, very few people completely conform to society's ideas about how gender should be expressed. We all fall somewhere along a spectrum.

We are going to do a worksheet that allows you to think through your gender identity and what it means for you. Please use the questions on Handout 1 as a guide for reflection on these terms and topics.

Handout 1: Gender Identity

Distribute Handout 1.

Partner Sharing (for groups of 6 or more)

Find a partner, and discuss your answers to questions 1, 2, and 3 from Handout 1. After 10 minutes, we'll come together as a large group to share our thoughts.

Large Group Sharing

Questions for generating large-group discussion can include:

- *What was something that stood out to you in your conversation with your partner?*
- *How did the free-write go; did you find the questions difficult to answer? Why or why not?*
- *What is something you do to express your gender?*
- *How do you think others perceive your gender identity? (For example, what do you think are some cultural narratives about what “being a woman” means?)*
- *Are there any questions about these terms and how we're using them?*

Lesson 2: Gender Roles and Expectations

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

Last session, we discussed the difference between sex and gender, and discussed what our gender identities mean for how we see ourselves and how others perceive different gender identities. Today, we're talking about expectations people have for us based on our gender. Gender roles are ideas about how genders, usually men and women, are meant to behave and the qualities they are expected to have. Sometimes this is so ingrained as to seem "obvious," like the expectation of men to be masculine and women to be feminine. Different social and cultural ideas about what masculinity and femininity are can make this topic even more complicated.

We're going to take some time now to reflect on our understanding of gender roles and expectations.

Handout 2: Gender Roles and Expectations

Distribute Handout 2.

Large Group Discussion

Discussion prompts for questions 1 + 2 on Handout 2:

- *What qualities did you describe as expected of women and feminine folks?*
- *What qualities did you describe for men and masculine folks?*
- *How did it feel to list these qualities? (If additional prompting is needed: Did it feel frustrating or limiting?)*
- *How might race and culture influence the kind of words you chose?*

Discussion prompts for questions 3 + 4 on Handout 2

- *Did you see yourself in this list of qualities?*
- *What are some potential pitfalls to these expectations and qualities?*

- Who gets left out of the narrative in these lists? (If additional prompting is needed: What about people who don't feel masculine or feminine? What if people's expectations for how someone of your gender are different from the expectations you have of yourself?)
- How might these expectations be used against you? (If additional prompting is needed: Do expectations of women and femmes sometimes require their submission, silence, or emotional labor? Do expectations of men sometimes require that they hide their vulnerability, emotions, insecurity?)
- (How) do you see these expectations being enforced? (Examples: "My dad tells me to 'man up' when I show sadness or vulnerability," "My family says I should focus on my appearance and act less confident or intelligent to attract partners.")
- Are there any questions about these ideas and concepts?

Lesson 3: Toxic Masculinity

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

We've spent some time talking about our experience with gender and about what behavior and social roles society might expect from us based on our gender. Today, we're going to talk about one very specific outcome of gendered expectations: toxic masculinity. That combination of worlds sometimes makes people defensive— but the term is not a condemnation of men or masculine folks, nor a critique of masculinity in and of itself.

This is a very specific critique of one way of performing masculinity.

Toxic masculinity is masculinity that relies on violence, sexual conquest, and financial and social status. Toxic masculinity is the result of many factors: social pressures that impact men, and a mindset that devalues women and femininity. Like the downfalls of gender roles we discussed last session, this kind of masculinity can be frustrating and limiting. Masculinity that relies on external factors like the obedience of loved ones is hard to control and is difficult and stressful to sustain. It is damaging for folks

practicing toxic masculinity and the people close to them, who may experience emotional and physical violence as a result. As we discussed, society can often support toxic masculinity in its support of gender roles and expectations. But our goal is to identify and shift away from toxic masculinity in ourselves or in the people around us.

Can you identify instances and examples of toxic masculinity in popular culture? This would mean a kind of masculinity that supports violence, devalues women and femininity, and pursues status through other people's submission.

Examples may include people and events like:

- Recent cases involving sexual assault and violence
- Resistance to the #MeToo movement

It's important to note that there are lots of ways to be men or be masculine that are not toxic, and that practicing toxic masculinity is not exclusive to men. Can you think of examples of expressions of masculinity that are not toxic? That is, masculinity that does not rely on violence, ownership and abuse of women and femininity, and achieving status through obedience and coercion.

Examples for characteristics include:

- Kindness and gentleness
- Respect for those around them
- Willingness to show emotion and vulnerability

Some examples from popular culture might include:

- Mr. Rogers
- Bob Ross
- Dwayne Wade
- Chadwick Boseman

(Note: Popular culture examples may not stand the test of time. Please use different or more relevant examples as needed.)

Partner Activity

In pairs, discuss examples and experiences with toxic masculinity you've had in your life. Be prepared to discuss with the larger group!

Large Group Sharing

- *What did you discuss in your pairs?*
- *Have you had experiences with masculinity that did not rely on violence, control, and status? What was that like?*
- *Are there any questions about toxic masculinity and its impact?*